

10
PATHAN VS HINDUSTAN

1996, THE year I debuted, was a happening one.

First, Sri Lanka beat Australia comprehensively and won the final of the World Cup at Lahore by seven wickets. Then, Dada and The Wall arrived: Sourav Ganguly and Rahul Dravid both debuted in Test cricket, with scores of 131 and 96, respectively. The legendary Dickie Bird umpired his last Test at Lord's. And Wasim bhai, at his peak, took his 300th Test wicket.

The following year, Pakistan's 50th year of Independence, I visited India for the first time to play the Independence Cup, a quadrangular ODI tournament featuring Sri Lanka, New Zealand, Pakistan and the hosts.

With my smashing debut and the successful Australia tour under my belt at the start of the year, I knew I was in for a thrilling ride. Playing in the hot summer months in India wasn't ideal, but most of the games were day-night matches and we weren't going to let the weather get in the way of our trying to beat India at home.

Too bad India got their car keys handed to them early in that series. They beat the Kiwis in one game and were demolished by both Sri Lanka and Pakistan. Our team didn't feature Wasim bhai, Waqar bhai and the wily Mushtaq Ahmed – all three were busy playing county cricket in England. Without three of the game's greatest bowlers, our bowling looked weak on paper. But we were not weak-willed.

Ramiz bhai was captain of the side. We played in our famous light-green jerseys, my favourite kit over all these years. The hype around the tournament was insane. As for me, I wanted the great Indian experience: movie stars, the Taj Mahal and bhel puri. But more than anything else, I wanted Pakistan to beat India in all our games in that series.

As for the welcome and fanfare, it was unrelenting and unprecedented. I wasn't expecting what I got in India, honestly. The way we were followed around by the press, the way the fans used to wait near hotel elevators for hours to see us … It's true – India really is the modern hub of international cricket. The sport is a religion, a cult, a state within the state and a way of life in